

Trial Thirteen

Progress remains... slow, at least towards my initial goals. The splinters refuse to behave like the Shimmer Tree. They do not lure, bind, or pacify the spirit; instead they trap and crudely gnaw at it. Imprecise but undeniably energetic. Still, more work is needed for this to work practically.

The latest subject survived forty-three minutes longer than the predictions suggested. Impressive, yes, but also problematic, as he spent nearly all of that period immobilized by his own tensed muscle. It's hard to imagine he was truly conscious for that, but still I apologized out of habit. What fascinates me is the resilience the splinter induces. It is not healing, nothing so orderly, it is more like a frantic refusal to cease. Muscles reknit crookedly. Veins harden like wire. Even the eyes try to bloom into strange, iridescent petals. The effect is grotesque, yes, but undeniably durable. Energetic and durable.

During disassembly I discovered something unexpected: blood-red thorns growing out of the subjects white bone. This was certainly outside of the subjects' usual physicality and surely due to some random mutation and not a property of the Shimmer Tree itself. No signs of the white latticework from the last experiment, unless... no that couldn't be it. Bone is the wrong shade of white, the tree's white is more like ice. I'm beginning to think that mortal souls are the wrong avenue for future investigation, but this accidental merger of humanoid and tree is inspiring new and terrible ideas. For the war effort, I suppose. I keep remembering how even failed subjects cling fiercely to existence. One expired body continued twitching for nearly an hour after total organ collapse, equal parts impressive and inconvenient. Responsibly, I had to incinerate it.

The next splinter is soaking now. I will try a narrower cut in the morning. If I can avoid another vocal bloom, all the better, I don't need any more nosy neighbors.